

THROUGH THE AGES

Beauty

Women have aspired to meet socially constructed notions of beauty and the “ideal” body shape since prehistory. In the last decade or so, however, women have begun to reject such ideas and to embrace bodies of all types and sizes.

THE EARLIEST REPRESENTATIONS of the female body are around 25,000 years old—the so-called “Venus figurines” found in Austria that feature pear-shaped figures with large busts. For most of recorded history, cultures have considered this shape the optimum for childbearing, and therefore a desirable aesthetic, which is seen reproduced in art from ancient Greek statues of Aphrodite, the goddess of love and beauty, and Rubens’s 17th-century portraits to the pinups of the 1950s.

A voluptuous body was, and still is, considered preferable on many Polynesian islands. Young women adhere to a practice known as *ha’apori* (to fatten), in which they are encouraged to put on weight to appear more fertile. In Europe and the US during the 19th century, the “fertile” or hourglass look was defined by a large bust and a small waist, which made the hips look curvier. Corsetry for pushing up the bust and minimizing the waist therefore became a key aspect of dress. The 19th-century practice of tight-lacing took this to extremes, with women laced into corsets that pushed in the ribs to create a smaller waist. Other

examples of body modification in the name of beauty are the brass neck coils that are worn by the Kayan women in Asia, which compress the clavicle and create the impression of an unnaturally long neck, and the lip plates worn by Mursi women in Africa, which signal that a woman is of marriageable age.

Desire for a white complexion

Pale skin has been a beauty aspiration since at least ancient Egyptian times, because it has been seen to indicate that a woman was privileged enough to spend her time indoors rather than working outside in the fields where her skin would catch the sun. The trend for white skin endures in Southeast Asia, where whitening products dominate cosmetic counters, and skin-bleaching treatments are commonplace. Eyelid surgery with the aim of opening up the eye shape to make it look bigger and more European is also popular among young women in the region.

“A culture fixated on female **thinness** is ... an obsession about female **obedience**.”

NAOMI WOLF, *THE BEAUTY MYTH*, 1991



◀ For a leggy look

Unable to procure silk or nylon hosiery during World War II, many women resorted to painting their legs with nude-colored makeup such as Leg Silque Liquid Stockings.